



COMING TO THE AID OF THE ELDERLY

Self-isolation made less strenuous for the elderly via technology

Dhriti Datta | dhriti@digit.in

The COVID-19 pandemic has caused the world to be relegated to the confines of their homes, in order to stay safe and healthy. In India, the outbreak has led to a rightly-implemented lockdown of the country further ensuring that people don't venture out in this treacherous situation. However, for the elderly or senior citizens that stay alone, this situation can seem quite daunting. Most senior citizens in India shy away from utilising online services, rely on cash more than online transactions

and also prefer shopping for groceries and other necessities in physical stores. However, the need of the hour has called upon change, and change they must. This is especially true for seniors (above the age of 60), since the virus seems to have a higher morbidity rate for this demographic. Nevertheless, unlike pandemics in the past, we now have the power of technology in our hands which ensures we remain connected even when in isolation. Here's how technology, along with some assistance from you, can ensure that the seniors stay connected during

the outbreak and have access to all their necessities.

STAYING CONNECTED

Communication with family and friends is possibly the most integral thing for the elderly during periods of self-isolation. Not just for their physical health, but also their mental health. The constant fear-mongering in the media, conspiracy theories floating around on WhatsApp and misinformation from various sources can leave people, especially seniors, feeling anxious. Talking to loved ones can ease some of this stress. Therefore, services such as WhatsApp voice/video calls, Skype, Hangouts, Facebook Messenger and more, can connect elders to their family across the country or even world.

You can explain the process of setting up these apps over the phone in a detailed manner, if they don't already have them activated and can also teach them how to video/voice call, or even simply send voice notes on these apps. If they're using a smartphone, ensure that you make it easier for them to use by increasing text size, applying all of their most-used apps to the home-screen or a separate screen on iOS, and even turn on text-to-speech for news apps, social media and more. This is especially useful if they have visual impairments and cannot see the text properly on smartphone screens.

If your senior relatives stay alone and away, you can assume remote control over their PC in case you want to help them fix internet issues, show them how to use certain websites or online services and more. Remote management software such as RemotePC, LogMeIn and TeamViewer are popular in this regard. The software must be installed on both PCs, so you'll likely have to guide them through the installation process. But hey, you can always do this over those nifty video calls on an array of mobile apps, as we mentioned earlier.

SHOPPING FOR NECESSITIES

Even though grocery and food stores have remained open even during the shutdown, it is riskier for older adults to venture out to these physical stores